

servers, firewalls and other solutions on open source, our client wanted to shift SAP, its mission-critical application, onto Linux in a cluster environment.

"While deploying the solution, the implementers got stuck at the clustering phase, so our client invited us to take on the challenge. After understanding SAP and the cluster environment over 15 days, we began work, and soon deployed the solution successfully. This won us accolades for our delivery and customisation abilities for open source-based solutions, and led to the initiation of a fruitful partnership with Red Hat," says Gupta. Eventually, Keen and Able got many customers like IndiaBulls, ESPN/Star Sports and Sheela Foam to run their mission-critical applications on open source, and truly enjoy its benefits.

But how lucrative were these open source-based offerings for K&A? The business model it adopted was that of a 'support seller', wherein it did not charge for the (open source) software itself, but charged for custom development and support (maintenance and server support) services. Just by providing Linux support and customised solutions, Keen and Able generated a business of Rs 1 million per annum initially, amounting to as much as 20 per cent of its business. The path, however, wasn't free of hurdles. "We struggled for the first 3 to 4 years. Building a dedicated team to sell the solutions, and exploring what we could do and deliver, were some of the initial challenges we faced," says Gupta. The addition of training services and diversification of the business a few years later helped mitigate some of the problems.

Strengthening business roots

With time, there arose the need to expand the range of solutions on offer, and to create a more holistic business model. Keen and Able went beyond maintenance services, which today constitute only 15 per cent of its revenue, and provided ready-to-implement projects, solutions around network security and servers, and even corporate training. "We developed software for the various requirements of different customers, and not for only infrastructure deployment as in our initial days. Today, we are into development, training and consulting activities," says Gupta. About 50 per cent of the firm's revenue comes from consulting, customisation and deployment of open source products.

Keen and Able also built a good business around training, which it ventured into in 2006, after facing a severe shortage of skilled people. What started as a cost centre became a profit centre in about two years. "Entering into training happened due to our personal experience of not being able to find suitable talent. We saw a huge gap between certified professionals and professionals who had learnt by themselves. We felt the need for formal training to fill this gap. Thus, we looked at Red Hat certification. Initially, we got about 10-15 of our own professionals trained. Soon we realised that we had a large talent pool

with not just bookish knowledge, but on-site experience, and decided to venture into imparting training," says Gupta. Today, as much as 35 per cent of Keen and Able's revenue comes from its training arm, FOSTERING Linux.

In parallel, the firm's strategy to reach out to new customers also evolved over time. It followed a twin strategy of getting customers talking to customers, and starting small to build confidence in new customers. "Customers talking to customers' works much better than 'vendor talk'. We get a new customer to talk to an existing customer with similar requirements, to build confidence in us—and until date, it has worked very well for us. We also advise our customers to start small, try our POC (proof of concept), and then go into it in full swing," says Gupta.

Despite a mature business model and selling strategy, obstacles remained. While entering into training did provide a vast talent pool for Keen and Able and helped resolve the early talent crunch, finding the right kind of professionals still remains a problem. "A major challenge today is to find professionals with the right aptitude, or 'open-sourceness' as I call it. The attitude of learning about open source just for a good job doesn't work for us, or for any open source vendor. We need people who cannot accept 'No' as an answer to a problem. Such people are in short supply. We have some, but need many more to reach the zenith," says Gupta.

A peep into the future!

Looking ahead, Keen and Able hopes to come out with its own open source product to contribute back to the community. "We have been working on a diverse range of solutions over the years, and shall soon productise them. Plans have already been made. We just have to get the team together, package the product and it will be ready for consumption," says Gupta. "In the future, we also hope to explore untouched domains in open source, and address the issues prevalent there. We have set a growth target of 100 per cent this year, and are already on the right track towards achieving it," adds Gupta. Keen and Able sees tremendous opportunities in the government, in the embedded devices domain and in the SME sector. It also sees a lot of potential in the Android and Maemo platforms. "For companies like us, open source is the way ahead, as it brings down the initial capital expenditure and the resultant set-up costs," says Gupta.

So, do not be reluctant to explore the opportunities open source offers adventurous start-ups. Keen and Able Computers has shown that there's a whole open world out there, waiting to be tapped. 

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The author loves to experiment, and writing for LINUX For You is her latest experiment—so beware! Just a minute, she also happens to be a journalist during the day.